



DELHI | Drone Dread

At a time when reliable intelligence is needed for internal security, the National Technical Research Organisation (NTRO) has been forced to ground all its Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs) owing to their overall unsafe and open radio links. Even the 100-odd UAVs deployed by the armed forces on the border are under threat because of insecure communication links. The UAVs, popularly called 'drones', are still flying but already there is a security impact assessment being carried out on them. The flying machines are meant to provide pictures and video feeds from inaccessible locations. The NTRO had deployed four UAVs and was waiting for eight more from the Israeli Aerospace Industry (IAI) at a cost of Rs 350 crore. The deal had been sealed by the NTRO despite concerns from technical experts. Alarm bells rang after it was revealed that US drones had been hacked by Iraqi insurgents by using a \$26 off-the-shelf software programme called SkyGrabber. Integrating an encryption device to work against the hacking programme is to be done in the UAVs by the Israelis, a process expected to take at least two years. Most of the UAV fleet in India comprises Herons and a few Searchers. The US deploys Predators, said to have a much safer communication link as compared to the Herons used by India.

THE HERON
AT THE PARIS
AIR SHOW

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

100

is the number of unmanned aircraft being used by the Indian military that are suspected of having unsafe radio links.